which had decreased, to which Schmidt – bolder than his predecessor – sarcastically replied that ‘the federal government was not able to act as a buyer’.7

Honecker returned to Berlin with an increased passion for foreign affairs and with first-hand knowledge of leading statesmen. It gave him satisfaction to chat with politicians such as French President Giscard d’Estaing, Finnish President Urho Kekkonen and the leaders of Italy, Norway, Denmark, Belgium and Sweden in the presence of the thirty-five signatories to the Final Act. His memoirs betrayed pride at the recognition gained at his first appearance on the world stage. ‘Most of these encounters were my first personal contacts,’ he recounted. ‘This opportunity of getting to know each other was doubtless in our mutual interests and conducive to trust and better understanding.’8

Funnily enough, Ford’s complaints about the seating in Helsinki had dimmed by early 1976, as a brief exchange regarding Honecker at the White House with Ambassador Cooper reveals, when the President remarked:

President: Tell me about things in East Germany. I had a couple of good talks with Honecker.

Cooper: He can’t stop talking about it. He had the pictures on the first page. He told me he felt as if you had been friends for twenty years. You’re telling him you and I were friends has helped me. He has really never gotten over it. May I tell him I saw you and you sent best wishes?

President: You certainly may.9